

2011 and since it is not free software, no community can support it or provide updates. Considering all these factors, the economic gains from the project are immense.”

Training for the *Janayugam* team

The Alpha Fork team trained the *Janayugam* employees and so there was no need for any fresh recruitment.

Training was given over five days, with a short course on the new free software stack. Scribus has more features compared to the old software. This helped to reduce the routine work done during the past 15 years. The two systems administrators who were experienced with Microsoft tools received two weeks of training on systems administration in GNU/Linux.

What is Scribus?

Scribus is a desktop publishing software with support for professional typesetting and image setting. It is equipped with CMYK support and ICC colour management. It has a built-in PDF creator, and can import multiple file formats like Pagemaker, Corel Draw, IDML, etc.

“It has Unicode support, which was not possible with Pagemaker. Complex Text Layout (CTL) enabled by the HOST-Oman Project (HOST - House of Open Source Technologies), gave Indic language support to Scribus. It is because of the CTL support that Malayalam Unicode typesetting became possible with Scribus,” says Ranjith Siji, co-founder, Alpha Fork.

Initially, it was believed that the migration to GNU/Linux from Windows would be difficult. But the entire staff adapted quickly and adjusted well to the new software. The focus of the training was to make the staff members understand the advantages of FOSS and to familiarise them with the new environment and tools. On the first day of the training programme, the staff was trained on how to use the KDE desktop environment, along with a few customised tools that were integrated with KDE to ease the workflow. The team says that KDE was chosen to reduce the learning period.

“We developed an ASCII-to-Unicode converter named ‘Janayugom Edit’ in order to support migration from ASCII content made using Pagemaker, to Unicode, supporting Scribus. It was inspired from the ‘payyans’ script developed by SMC (Swathanthra Malayalam Computing). We provided training on how to use it along with teaching the users the difference between ASCII and Unicode,” adds Ambady Anand S., full-stack Web developer and programmer at Alpha Fork Technologies.

Traditional Malayalam script in a production environment

On the second day of the training programme, the team was introduced to image editing tools in GNU/Linux. This included a small hands-on session on how to use GIMP and Inkscape. From the third day, the main session started with training on basic typesetting in Scribus. Ashok Kumar P. K., a professional in typesetter training says, “Providing training on how to use DTP software within three days, in order to be able to design a newspaper that has 14 bureaus and production centres spread across the state, was supposed to be an unmanageable task, but the employees were very cooperative and enthusiastic to learn the new package. Most of them had more than a decade of experience in DTP and that made things easier.”



Rajaji Mathew Thomas,
editor, Janayugom



Alpha Fork co-founder Mujeeb Rahman delivering a talk at a media event



The Kerala finance minister Thomas Isaac (left) honouring Malayalam traditional script advocate K. H. Hussain (right)